

Framing the News

India 2026

Replicating the PEJ 1999 Content Analysis for Indian Digital Journalism

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CONSTRUCTED WEEK: JAN–MAY 2026 · N = 170 STORIES · 12 OUTLETS

In 1999, the Project for Excellence in Journalism — working with Jay Rosen at NYU and Princeton Survey Research Associates — produced what remains the most cited content analysis in American journalism studies. That study coded 2,269 front-page stories from seven US newspapers, asking a deceptively simple set of questions: What narrative frames do journalists use? What triggers a story into existence? What subliminal messages does the news carry?

That study has never been replicated for India. Until now.

170

STORIES CODED

27.6%

STRAIGHT NEWS

25.2%

COMBATIVE FRAMES

1.2%

CONSENSUS

Draft — Not for publication. Legal review pending.

What the Numbers Say

The aggregate looks reassuring. Straight news — the inverted pyramid, no dominant narrative frame — accounts for 27.6% of all homepage stories. In PEJ’s American study, the figure was 16%. Indian digital journalism, taken as a whole, is more fact-based than American newspapers were at the turn of the century.

But this aggregate masks a structural fracture.

Split the 12 outlets into digital natives and legacy-digital operations, and the numbers diverge violently. Legacy outlets use straight news 37.1% of the time. Digital natives use it 12.3% — a 3:1 ratio. This is not a quality gap. It is a philosophical divide. Legacy outlets default to reporting what happened. Digital natives default to interrogating what it means. The Wire frames 27% of its homepage stories around conflict. NDTV frames 67% as straight news. These are not the same species of journalism wearing different clothes.

Combative framing — conflict, horse race, wrongdoing exposed — runs at 25.2%. Close to PEJ’s 30%, but distributed differently. In the US, combativeness clustered around government reporting. In India, it concentrates in election coverage. When elections trigger the story, horse-race framing shoots to 58.3%. The frame becomes almost reflexive.

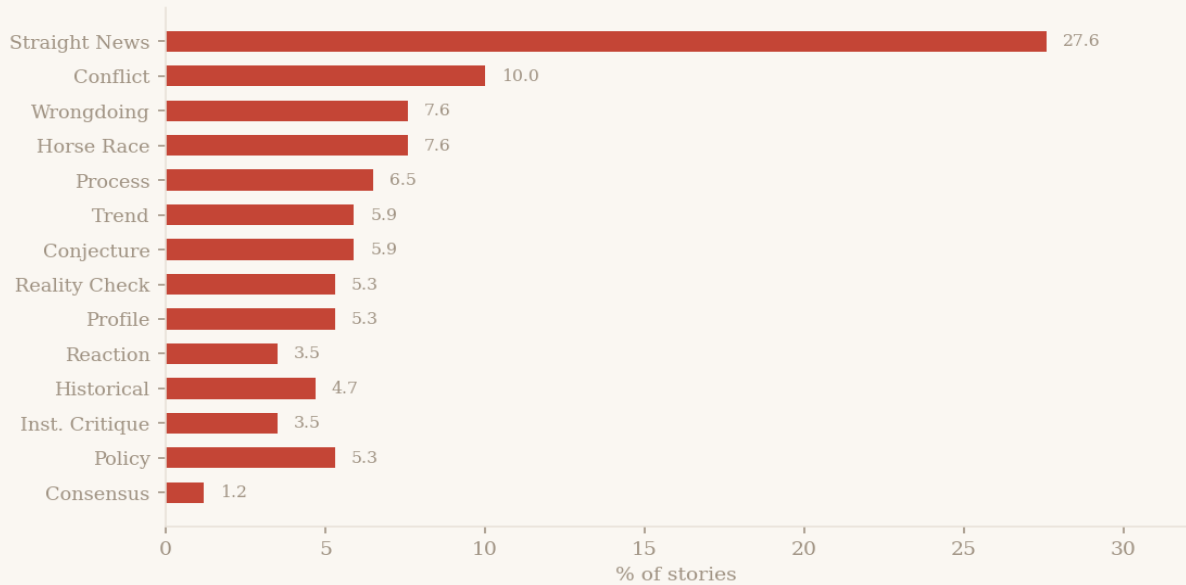
Here is the devastating number: **1.2%**.

That is the share of Indian digital news stories framed around consensus — points of agreement. Two stories out of 170. In PEJ’s American study — which itself noted the poverty of consensus framing — the figure was 6%. India’s number is one-fifth of that. In a polity that has just conducted five simultaneous state elections, is navigating a US tariff war, managing fallout from a Middle East conflict affecting its oil supply, and processing post-election violence in Bengal — the press cannot find a single story worth telling through the lens of common ground. This is not a finding about Indian society. It is a finding about Indian journalism’s storytelling reflexes.

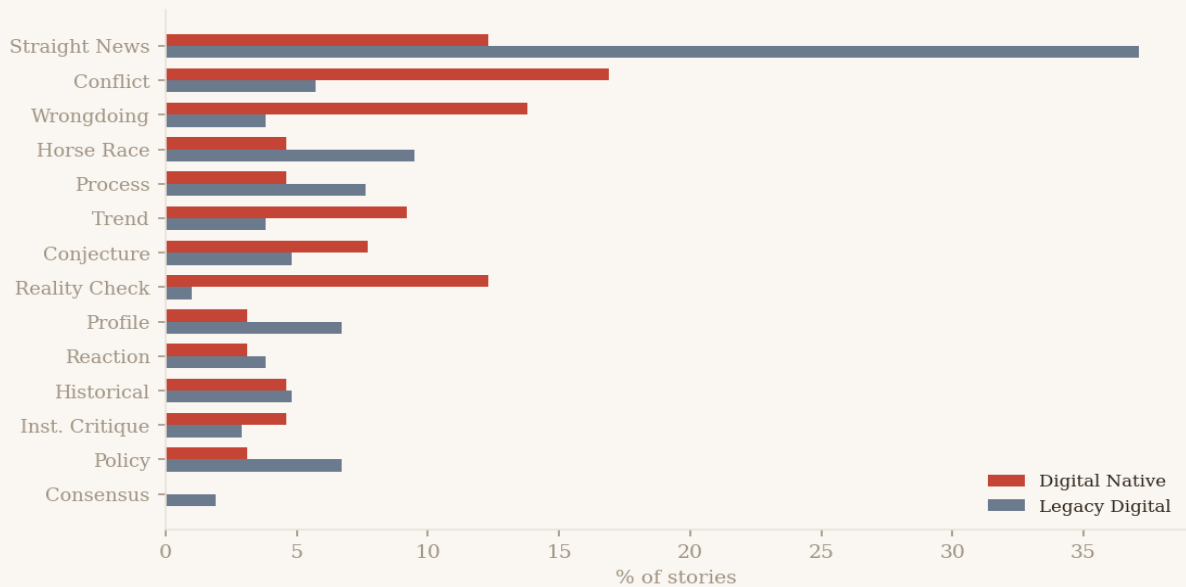
One finding is unambiguously healthy. When Indian digital journalists go out and get the story themselves — enterprise reporting, not responding to government statements or breaking events — the dominant frame is wrongdoing exposed (25%). PEJ found that American enterprise journalism defaulted to personality profiles and trend stories. Indian enterprise journalism is accountability journalism. It does not profile the powerful; it investigates them.

Frame Distribution

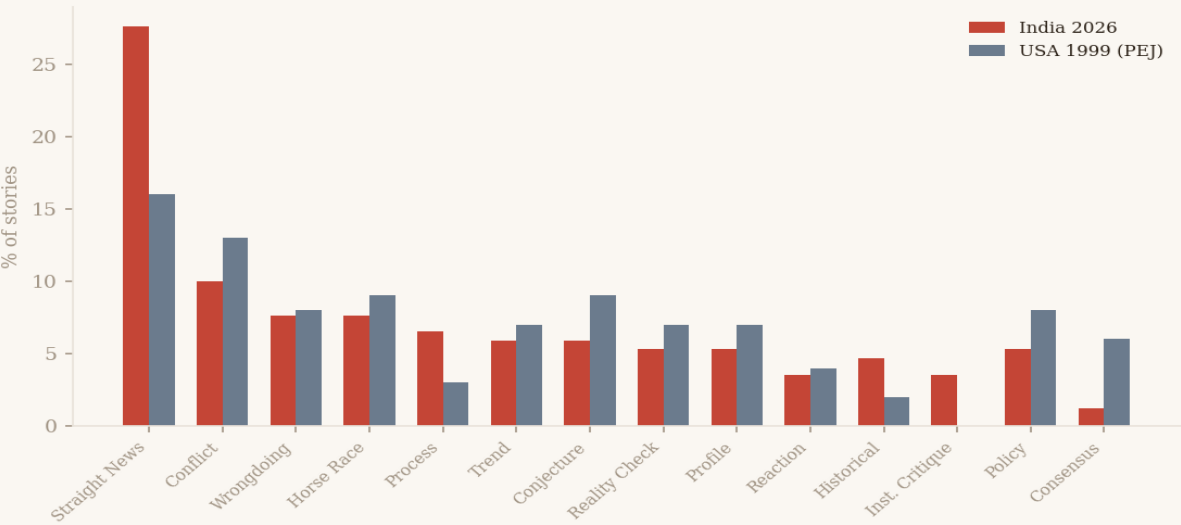
NARRATIVE FRAMES — ALL 12 OUTLETS (N = 170)



DIGITAL NATIVE vs LEGACY DIGITAL

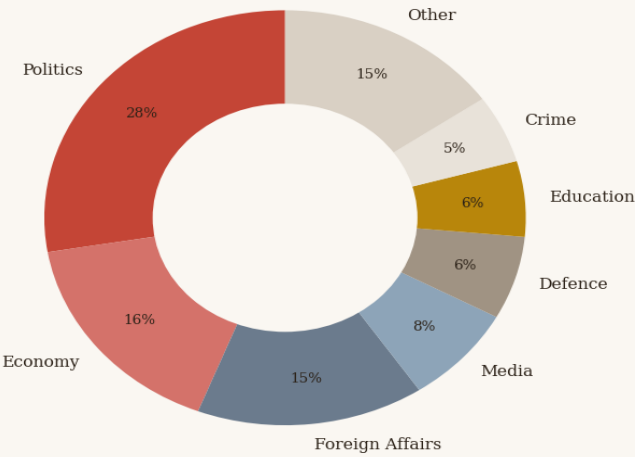


India 2026 vs. PEJ USA 1999



India shows higher straight-news prevalence and lower consensus framing. Institutional Critique is India-specific.

TOPIC DISTRIBUTION



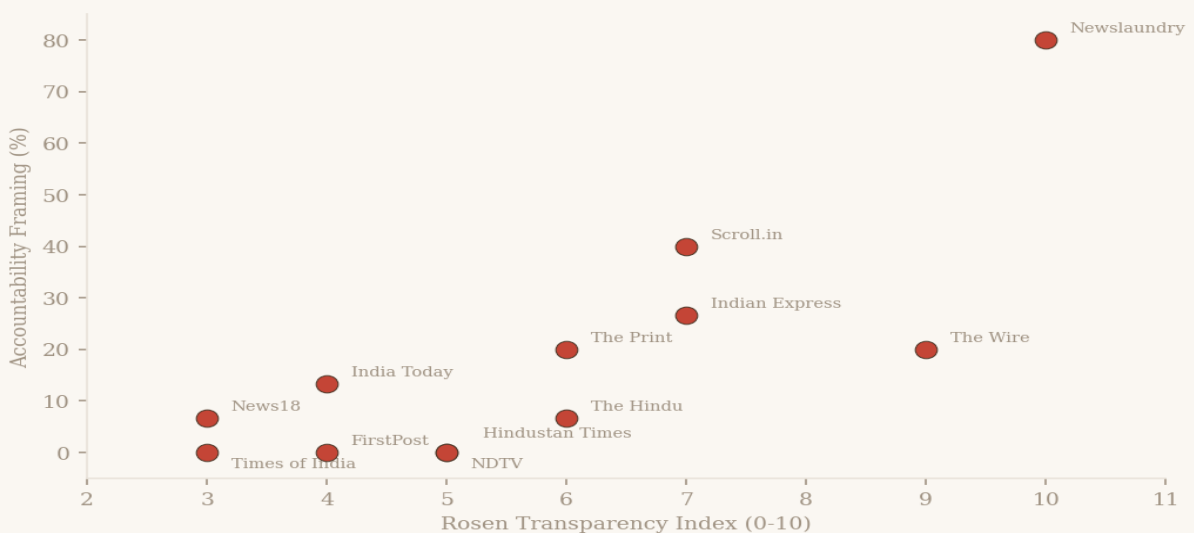
Politics/Elections dominates at 27.6%, matching PEJ's 26%. Economy/Business second at 16.5%, Foreign Affairs at 15.3%.

The Funding Model Is the Frame

The correlation is near-perfect. Score each outlet on Jay Rosen’s transparency criteria — disclosed funding, corrections policies, editorial stance, proprietor separation, reader accountability — and plot it against accountability framing output. The result should terrify any corporate-funded newsroom claiming editorial independence.

Newslaundry (Rosen 10/10, fully reader-funded, complete transparency) devotes 80% of its editorial output to accountability frames. Scroll.in (7/10) runs 40%. Indian Express (7/10) runs 27%. NDTV, Hindustan Times, Times of India, FirstPost — all corporate-funded, all employing what Rosen calls “the view from nowhere” — produce zero accountability framing on their homepages. This is not a matter of individual editorial courage. It is structural. The data says your frame is your funding.

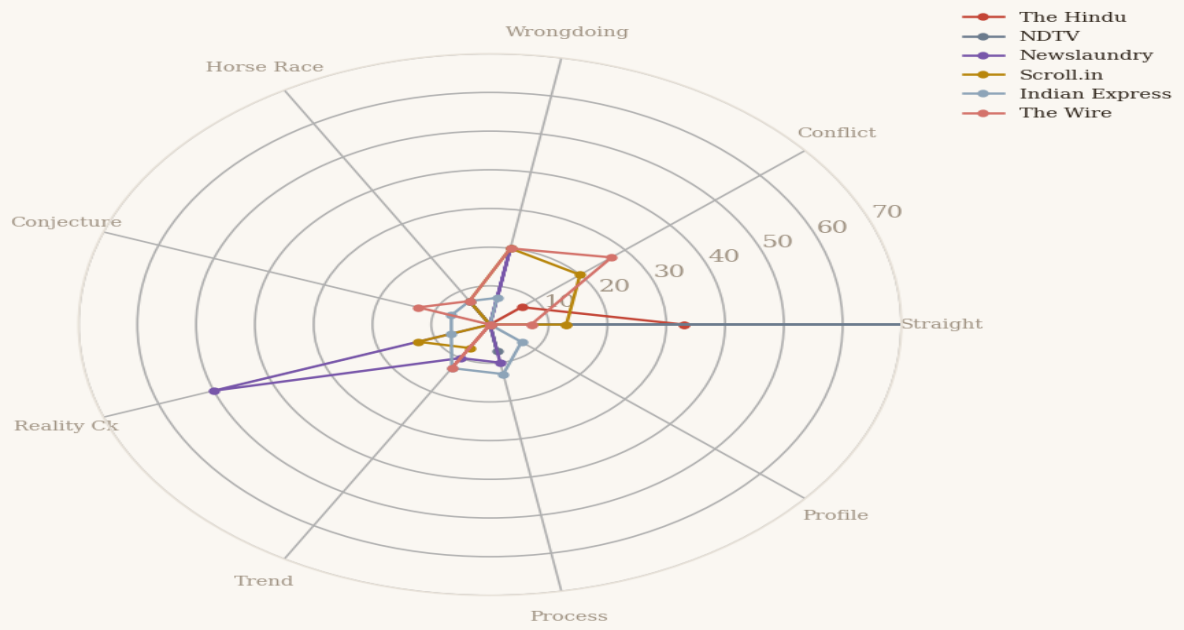
ROSEN TRANSPARENCY INDEX vs ACCOUNTABILITY FRAMING



THE HINDU: POLICY JOURNALISM'S OUTLIER

One outlet breaks the legacy mould entirely. The Hindu devotes 26.7% of its homepage to policy-explored framing — five times the field average of 5.3%. It is the only legacy outlet to produce a consensus-framed story in the entire sample. Its historical-outlook framing (13.3%) is nearly triple the field average. In a landscape where legacy digital defaults to straight news and digital natives default to conflict or accountability, The Hindu defaults to explanation. It asks what a policy means rather than who wins or who is to blame.

OUTLET FINGERPRINTS — RADAR COMPARISON



Deuze Typology & Rosen Index

Outlet	Deuze Type	Rosen Voice	Funding	Score	Acct.%
Newslandry	Meta & Comment	Full Transparency	100% reader-funded	10/10	80.0%
The Wire	Mainstream News	Disclosed Standpoint	Donations + grants	9/10	20.0%
Scroll.in	Mainstream News	Disclosed Standpoint	Private	7/10	40.0%
Indian Express	Mainstream News	Moderate Transparency	Private group	7/10	26.7%
The Print	Mainstream News	Moderate Transparency	Private	6/10	20.0%
The Hindu	Mainstream News	Moderate Transparency	Private (THG)	6/10	6.7%
NDTV	Mainstream News	View from Nowhere	Corporate (Adani)	5/10	0.0%
Hindustan Times	Mainstream News	View from Nowhere	Corporate (Birla)	5/10	0.0%
India Today	Mainstream News	View from Nowhere	Corporate	4/10	13.3%
FirstPost	Mainstream News	View from Nowhere	Corporate (Reliance)	4/10	0.0%
Times of India	Index & Category	View from Nowhere	Corporate (Bennett)	3/10	0.0%
News18	Mainstream News	View from Nowhere	Corporate (Reliance)	3/10	6.7%

TRIGGER → FRAME TENDENCIES

Trigger	Dominant Frame	%	PEJ Parallel
Govt Statement	Straight News	46.3%	PEJ: 40% combative; India more fact-reported
Enterprise	Wrongdoing Exposed	25.0%	PEJ: trends/profiles; India: accountability
Election Result	Horse Race	58.3%	Universal: elections trigger horse-race
Report/Data	Reality Check + Trend	55.6%	PEJ: explanation 19%, trend 24%
Spontaneous	Straight News	54.5%	Breaking news → inverted pyramid

How This Study Was Conducted

We adapted PEJ’s methodology for the Indian digital landscape, coding 170 homepage stories from 12 English-language outlets across a constructed week spanning January to May 2026. The constructed week technique — standard in media research — randomly selects one day of the week from each month, creating a representative sample that avoids single-event distortion.

Each story was coded on four variables: Frame (14 categories, including one India-specific addition), Topic (16), Trigger (12), and Underlying Message (9). The outlets split into Digital Natives (Scroll.in, The Wire, The Print, NewsLaundry, FirstPost) and Legacy Digital (NDTV, India Today, Hindustan Times, Indian Express, Times of India, News18, The Hindu).

After story-level coding, outlet-level classifications were applied: the Deuze Structural Typology (based on the outlet’s architecture and linking patterns), the Rosen Transparency Index (scored on five criteria), and the C:E Ratio (commentary-to-evidence, derived from source-type data).

LIMITATIONS

English-only. Hindi, Tamil, Bengali, and other language digital ecosystems have different ownership structures, political orientations, and framing tendencies. They deserve their own study.

Homepage bias. We sampled only prominent homepage stories. Stories buried deeper in the site may show different framing patterns.

Single coder. AI-coded with consistent rules but no independent human verification. The full coded dataset is published for audit.

Five-month window. Dominated by state elections and their aftermath. Quarterly updates will test whether patterns hold outside election cycles.

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Quarterly frame-shift updates available. Baseline: May 2026.

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